

Check Please!

Reliability and Service are two sides of the same coin—a coin moulded from the metal of Expectations. The only difference being that the markings of one side depict the build quality of the product while the other side reflects the support provided by the company. For instance, when we buy a new car from a reputed company, we don't expect it to break down. When it does, we expect a certain quality of service from the authorised garage that we sent it to for repairs.

But what happens when the problem is not rectified? We feel unsatisfied or worse, cheated. Why? Because our expectations were not met.

This simple matter of failed expectations is a cause of concern for the PC industry.

Cutthroat competition in recent times has resulted in price wars that have forced PC makers to curb spending and cut corners at every step. This affects the quality of their products in one way or another. Also, with customers looking to buy PCs with the latest and fanciest of technologies, the likelihood of failure increases, as more features means more parts that could fail.

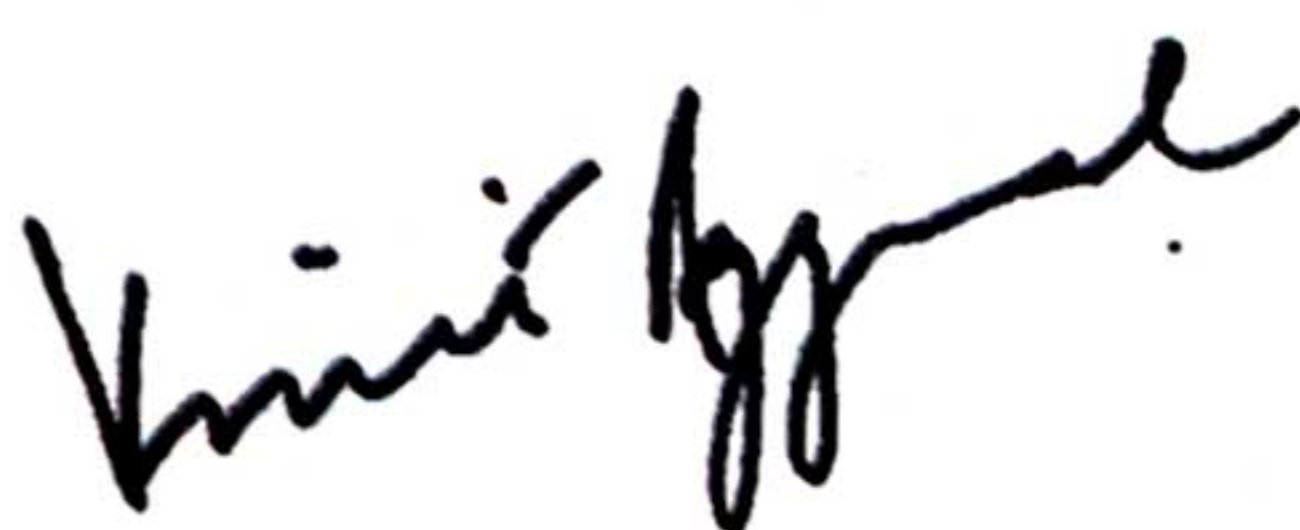
But computer manufacturers aren't investing as much as they need to in service and support. Herein lies the root of the problem.

A company might have the best development team, top-notch management, excellent marketing strategists and financial advisors, but if its customer service department is not properly trained, it's headed for disaster. These support personnel, be it the field engineers or the telephonic customer support staff, are the frontline foot soldiers who connect with the customers on a continuous basis and are often the key to success or failure.

A hospital might have the best surgeons and physicians, but a single ill-trained nurse can cause much harm to its goodwill as the actual and continuous connect of the patient happens with the nursing staff. Similarly, a PC maker's customer service staff is the one that directly interfaces with the company's customers. There's just too much at stake for companies to skimp on their proper training and on the constant upgradation of their service and support networks.

But companies still do. This is where we, the customers, can help set things straight. We need to start demanding more. We need to be more vociferous in communicating our expectations and only accepting the right service and nothing less. For any company that's serious about its business will listen to its customers.

Either that, or it needs to invent PCs that never crash or fail.



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